The Third Path: Principles, Boundaries, Trade-offs, and Falsifiable Tests.

Author: Nguyen Duc Tri - Founder of the Adaptive Intelligence Circle Foundation
Published by: Adaptive Intelligence Circle Foundation.

Date: November 2026

Introduction

This is one of the most important documents since the Whitepaper v1.0 was published in September 2026. It was created with the goal of helping the community, especially legislators, programmers, and the open-source community, to fully and deeply understand the Third Way. I wanted to write this document because I understand the consequences, boundaries, and limitations of the Third Way. Any idea has its own category, and the Third Way is no exception. It was created with the goal of serving human meaning, not opposing AI or major institutions. This is the first thing I want to emphasize before beginning the important parts of this document. We are entering a new era where the boundaries between humans and machines are increasingly blurred. We hope everyone will embrace it with enthusiasm and constructiveness.

Table of Contents

I. Principles

II.Boundaries

III.Trade-offs

IV.Falsifiable Tests

V.We are not

VI.Conclusions

Part I: Principles

I would like to reiterate a little of what was said in the Whitepaper, which is that the third path has been considered as an ideology, a new way of looking at the world after the fundamental shifts of the 20th century. The world order has changed after the Internet and decentralized infrastructures became new platforms of power, capable of strongly determining almost all aspects of life and also leaving consequences that the world is now facing. As we know, tribalism has existed throughout more than a thousand years of human history, appearing in socio-cultural issues as well as philosophical issues and becoming increasingly evident in the technological world. When the AI wave hit in 2022 with the advent of ChatGPT, marking a turning point for OpenAI and the entire Silicon Valley at the time, the world entered a new era with a relentless race among large, small and medium institutions. Debates about safety and the future of humanity were placed on a scale of urgent, even vital, issues for all of civilization. Most recently, the US-China summit at the end of September 2026 pushed the issue of AI governance to the national and regional levels – highlighting the importance of

building an ecosystem and establishing rules or regulations that benefit healthy competition. Continuously emphasizing governance rules and adaptation is the foundation of the third path. To be understood correctly, the third path is not simply about finding a middle ground between major institutions; it is how a nation or organization can survive in an increasingly fragmented world without losing its principles while simultaneously diminishing its ability to become a new center of power. This is crucial because becoming a new center of power can bring wealth in resources, trade, and intellectual authority, but it also has the potential to create a difficult-to-replace bottleneck, which could lead to systemic collapse if conflicts of interest and institutional constraints arise. This may be one of the greatest cognitive paradoxes of the 20th and 21st centuries, as most of us believe there is a default middle ground, and we are completely passive and unaffected. Frankly, the third path also has certain limitations; it's not entirely correct in every case. While it offers undeniable benefits to both the subject and the object, it also requires autonomy, caution, and unconstrained cooperation. Therefore, I believe future debates will revolve around this third path, as it may open up a new avenue. We don't necessarily deny the contradictions, but any organization, large or small, is living with paradoxes and limitations that could lead to disastrous consequences in the near future. This is an important topic before we move on to the next sections of this document.

Part II: Boundaries

This is one of the most important parts of the entire document. As I said, the third path also has certain limitations. The first limitation lies in the ability to avoid infringing on the interests of the stakeholders. This is a crucial objective. When talking about the third path, many people think that it will be free and above authority. This understanding is a mistake because the third path must still ensure that it contributes to the common goal. The common goal here includes sustainable development, emphasizing safety and transparency, and ensuring human values. This has been confirmed from the early days of the AIC Foundation when it tried to integrate human values into the entire system architecture, specifically within the Governance layer and the Ethical From Kernel layer of the entire "5+1" architecture. This is also a risky choice, as many large organizations are currently offering different definitions of AI Governance—how a system makes decisions, who determines those decisions, and who is responsible when the system fails. This is a huge question and could be expanded globally, especially as countries are increasingly tightening their strategies for autonomous technology or open-source release for large-scale data collection. The second limitation lies in the ability to support components without interfering with those that shouldn't be interfered with. A robust system doesn't mean controlling everything; instead, it can support various aspects without owning the object, based on pre-existing constraints before power is granted. In other words, a collaboration that doesn't create dominance—this becomes a broader question for the Human Meaning Network: how can people feel a sense of meaning within the system they exist in? The third limitation is that decentralization does not mean disregarding jurisdictional limits. It

means that a decentralized platform is still subject to legal pressure in the country where it is centralized. There is decentralization in technical terms, but at the same time, there is still centralization in governance and physical infrastructure, such as the sponsoring organization and third-party providers. A decentralized platform must ensure transparency in auditing, governance, and software supply chain risks, as well as legitimacy. These issues, while not entirely identical, complement each other to serve the goal of a public infrastructure that many organizations can reference, contribute to, or even leave the system. The fourth limitation is...recognizing a system with a mechanism that allows end users to exit while still ensuring data security. This means that a decentralized platform like Bitcoin or Ethereum can ensure that the protocol layer is not easily compromised, even if the upper layer is attacked by hackers. Furthermore, the fourth limitation emphasizes that it's impossible to completely avoid risk, but hypothetical functions like $safe()$ and $fork()$ can be built to ensure the system can operate stably under adverse conditions. These four limitations are currently still in the initial preconditions and may continue to be expanded in the coming years. These technological boundaries could become more intuitive if we apply them through a parallel test network, which AIC began prototyping around August 2026, before the first Whitepaper is released the following month. Viewing these boundaries from a strategic perspective reveals that the entire structure of the AIC Foundation is encompassed within these four limits: not just technical aspects, but also risk mitigation capabilities, international relations, and building legitimacy before wider deployment. The AIC Foundation didn't simply copy these experiences; it's the culmination of thousands of hours of work and learning from predecessors, comprehensively addressing the technological limitations of that era. Vitalik Buterin, Musk, Stallman, Linus, and even Pavel Durov are classic examples because they are not just tech entrepreneurs with millions of users, but are also understood and viewed from the perspective of power, trust, freedom, responsibility, systems, and human meaning in the digital age, all simultaneously clashing in an increasingly conflict-ridden and geopolitically complex world. These four limitations are the key to unlocking new questions about the Internet, AI, and Blockchain that humanity will have to answer in the next decade.

Part III: Trade-offs

This chapter will focus on the sacrifices the organization made in its early stages and how they shaped AIC into what it is today, although its size isn't the main topic. First, there were decisions that I consider to be contrary to common sense. This contraryness stems from a sensitivity to global issues, which many might consider overly idealistic or unrealistic. A specific example is the AIC Foundation's decision to pursue source code development before the Whitepaper was released – a decision few would make, as it wasn't valued by others or had the compelling initial story to attract investment like Silicon Valley projects. In other words, the transition to a Foundation model at the end of October 2026 and the submission to the DPGA – the most prestigious international digital asset organization – went against the trend of "technology first, institution

second." For AIC, these decisions aren't entirely correct, but they are very appropriate to the context in which AIC exists. The fact that the Global South – a region for many years considered a center of outsourcing and dependence on Western private technology – is gradually making progress in building its own technology, albeit in its early stages, is a positive sign. This indicates a shift in thinking about technological innovation, but it also requires the ability to expand networks and establish legitimacy – something the West has largely achieved over decades of development and evolution, and which is much more difficult for the South. However, it is precisely in this difficulty that Global South countries have the opportunity to interact with many different systems, and a deeper strength lies in their ability to adapt and withstand uncertainty. While the West views social systems through indicators and data, the South attempts to reduce them to the problem of diversity in thinking. Global South possesses a large pool of inexpensive labor and high levels of internet access, giving it the potential to deploy cross-border platforms without relying on third-party providers. This is precisely what I mentioned in the previous chapter when discussing the limitations of a decentralized system: Global South can play a role in establishing new intersections in the formation of digital public assets, not just Blockchain, but this becomes a space for the AIC Foundation with a completely different constructive mindset – an ethically coordinated infrastructure. The biggest question with the biggest trade-offs is: how can technology, ethics, decentralized governance, and human meaning coexist in one system without becoming a new center of power? But on another level, Global South also has limitations, particularly regarding intellectual property rights. Does it have the courage, the intellectual audacity, to tackle the major challenges facing humanity in the 21st century, or will it continue to depend on the Western world in the coming period? I believe this question will continue for at least the next 5-10 years as AI tends to become an infrastructure like electricity and water; at that point, the question will become urgent. The AIC Foundation isn't racing for scale or speed; it's striving to create a necessary balance between centralization and decentralization, between order and chaos, thereby unlocking new technological values where humans and technology can coexist in an ecosystem where the central role is no longer unique. This is a long-term effort and also represents the biggest trade-off since April 2025. Another thing I've realized during my work is that AIC currently emphasizes the spirit of succession, meaning the ability to survive and inherit in the future. Is this worthwhile? From my perspective, yes, and there will be many challenges ahead for the AIC Foundation to prove its value in the global technology ecosystem. This is a burden, a responsibility, but also an honor for a young founder in particular and AIC in general on the international stage.

Part IV: Falsifiable Tests

This section tests how the philosophy is applied in real life – a complex interwoven structure of thoughts, emotions, motivations, and techniques through a network called the Parallel TestNet. In this section, instead of focusing on the principles or the four limitations I mentioned in the previous section, the possibility of

failure of the third approach is anticipated. This doesn't completely negate the value of the third approach, but even the strict design principles will inevitably face difficulties or failures. I believe that if AIC fails, it's not necessarily a bad thing; it could be a lesson for those who follow to do better than what AIC has done. And if AIC succeeds, it could also be a challenge to its long-term sustainability. Regardless of the outcome, the fact that the third path has become one of the key principles of the AIC Foundation is a turning point in the thinking behind technological transformation. I think there are three types of "failures" that AIC will face in the near future:

- Very few people will follow the principle even if Parallel TestNet is implemented.

- Being forgotten or perceived as having an unclear stance.

- Large institutions continue to develop models with large data centers and mass-produce open models.

I don't deny these three situations; in fact, I consider them challenges for the AIC Foundation. These three situations are extremely real problems, stemming from socio-cultural and economic factors that diminish the significance of developing humanistic models that require high self-reliance and the ability to tolerate ambiguity in the long term. As I write this, I also recognize my own limitations: in terms of time, experience, health, and resource availability. Technically, my idea behind dividing into parallel networks is the ability to responsibly distribute risk. Parallel networks allow for multiple testing cycles in different environments and can reduce maintenance costs on a large scale through the self-inheritance of $P0, P1, P2, P3$, etc., on a "5+1" structure with Governance and Ethical From Kernel as the main components. At the same time, with its broad ecosystem, the AIC Foundation can encourage the development of public goods and independent foundations while still ensuring respect for transparent and responsible development principles. Parallel networks are a concept that is no longer unfamiliar to programming systems such as embedded programming or kernel programming. What's special is that it originated in Global South, specifically Vietnam, and compared to organizations like Ethereum or other blockchain projects, the implementation of parallel networks gives AIC a sense of caution and excitement regarding its practicality and security. This is a story I will discuss in more detail in subsequent articles.

Part V: We Are Not

This section affirms what AIC has never been and will never be. First, AIC is not a political organization: From the beginning, AIC has always emphasized that it is a non-profit organization aiming to research, build communities, and develop protocol solutions that create positive value globally. Joining the DPGA in October 2026 reinforces its transparent operations and contributions to the United Nations' Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). Second, AIC is not a commercial organization: with its Zero Donation Stance mechanism – meaning it does not accept investment from untrustworthy organizations, those incapable of implementation, or corporations/governments – AIC accepts short-term resource

scarcity to ensure its principles and direction remain aligned with its common goals. Thirdly, AIC is not a blockchain organization: This is the technology-related aspect, and AIC asserts that it does not sell tokens or solicit venture capital. Essentially, AIC aims for ethical public infrastructure, supporting the coordination of various systems. Fourthly, the AIC Foundation does not control the entire direction of the ecosystem. Essentially, since October 2026, AIC has split into a two-tier model: one for technology and the community (released in April 2025 as open-source code on various platforms) and an institutional tier with legal obligations, protecting the ecosystem and international relations through DPGA, Open Collective, The IO Foundation, Zenodo, etc. Fifthly, AIC is not a state/government-backed project. The AIC Foundation is an independent organization founded by Nguyen Duc Tri in April 2025, operating under the GPL-3.0 license – a responsible open license. Point 6: AIC affirms that any activities exploiting the name "AIC" to incite unrest will be strongly condemned. Point 7: AIC affirms that it is not a religious organization. Point 8: AIC affirms that all financial activities are conducted smoothly on the Open Collective platform – a global transparency platform that complies with anti-money laundering (AML) regulations. Point 9: AIC affirms that it respects all stakeholders, emphasizes neutrality, and focuses on core issues. And finally, AIC is not the only organization capable of achieving World Meaning Infrastructure (WMI). AIC is proud to be the organization that lays the foundation for this question and aims for an ecosystem of organizations researching meaningful and sustainable solutions.

Part VI: Conclusions.

This is the conclusion to this entire article. Frankly, this is one of the shorter articles compared to the Whitepaper, but it will help everyone understand more deeply the motivations, risks, and opportunities ahead for AIC. From the perspective of someone who has experienced nearly two years of ups and downs, AIC has become a part of the founder's life. It also means that AIC is not simply a project; it is an effort to create an opportunity for the development of ethical technology, not only for Global South but also for academic institutions worldwide seeking a new, more sustainable solution. AIC's success today is thanks to encouragement from the community, thousands of hours of thought and work, and a little luck that have created unforgettable milestones in its life. If I looked back at myself in December 2024 and said that there could be no extraordinary work, today, AIC and the entire community are striving to prove the opposite: that no matter who you are, or where you are in the world, you are all part of a common home, all responsible for nurturing the spirit of creative entrepreneurship, striving towards new hope, new joy. It could start with a line of code or, more simply, a random question in your head. The questions in this document may not be answered today, but that is precisely why we continue to move forward. With that, I will stop writing. AIC Foundation will continue on its chosen path in a simple, humble, and persistent way.

Founder, Nguyen Duc Tri.